

Alex chugs a Coke for breakfast and screams at Monica that he's ready to leave. Driving Monica to school was the string attached to the new Honda Dad and Mom gave Alex for his 17th birthday. Monica dashes through the kitchen, grabs a granola bar, and says good-bye to the cat. They're off.

Mom takes a quick massage shower and then enjoys a moment to herself, with a cup of coffee and a bowl of tasteless breakfast cereal. She remembers hearing, many years before, that the cardboard box her cereal comes in contains more nutrients than the product inside. She used to feed the kids a real breakfast every morning. She no longer feels guilty about leaving them on their own.

Mom dresses and then punches up her to-do list on the computer: buy groceries, call the therapist to arrange a makeup appointment, call Alex's high-school counselor to arrange to talk about his absenteeism and bad grades, call the car dealer and arrange a ten-thousand-mile checkup, call Mary Witherspoon to arrange lunch at the club, call . . . Mom sells life insurance in her "spare time." Most of the rest of the calls are to set up appointments with prospective clients.

Mom starts in on the telephone. A client puts her on hold and Mom asks the computer to balance her checkbook. She finds she's bumping against her overdraft limit. She decides to call the bank to arrange more credit. At the same time, she wonders if she could sell the branch manager a life-insurance policy.

Still on the phone, she touches up her fingernails and has the computer print out her shopping list. She straightens up the kitchen, feeds the cat, activates the burglar alarm, and heads off to the club.

After Mom's luncheon meeting and two sales calls, she does the grocery shopping. As always, she packs the frozen food and a bag of ice in the cooler she hauls around in the trunk of her car. She picks up Monica from school and drives her to her violin lesson in Hollywood. During Monica's